EXAMPLE 8.25

(a) A steam engine boiler is maintained at 250°C and water is converted into steam. This steam is used to do work and heat is ejected to the surrounding air at temperature 300K. Calculate the maximum efficiency it can have?

Solution

The steam engine is not a Carnot engine, because all the process involved in the steam engine are not perfectly reversible. But we can calculate the maximum possible efficiency of the steam engine by considering it as a Carnot engine.

$$\eta = 1 - \frac{T_L}{T_H} = 1 - \frac{300\,K}{523\,K} = 0.43$$

The steam engine can have maximum possible 43% of efficiency, implying this steam engine can convert 43% of input heat into useful work and remaining 57% is ejected as heat. In practice the efficiency is even less than 43%.

EXAMPLE 8.26

There are two Carnot engines A and B operating in two different temperature regions. For Engine A the temperatures of the two reservoirs are 150°C and 100°C. For engine B the temperatures of the reservoirs are 350°C and 300°C. Which engine has lesser efficiency?

Solution

The efficiency for engine A = $1 - \frac{373}{423} = 0.11$. Engine A has 11% efficiency

The efficiency for engine B = $1 - \frac{573}{623} = 0.08$

Engine B has only 8% efficiency.

Even though the differences between the temperature of hot and cold reservoirs in both engines is same, the efficiency is not same. The efficiency depends on the ratio of the two temperature and not on the difference in the temperature. The engine which operates in lower temperature has highest efficiency.



Diesel engines used in cars and petrol engines used in our motor bikes are all real heat engines. The efficiency of diesel engines has maximum up to 44% and the efficiency of petrol engines are maximum up to 30%. Since these engines are not ideal heat engines (Carnot engine), their efficiency is limited by the second law of thermodynamics. Now a days typical bikes give a mileage of 50 km per Liter of petrol. This implies only 30% of 1 Liter of petrol is converted into mechanical work and the remaining 70% goes out as wasted heat and ejected into the surrounding atmosphere!

8.9.3 Entropy and second law of thermodynamics

We have seen in the equation (8.66) that the quantity $\frac{Q_H}{T_H}$ is equal to $\frac{Q_L}{T_L}$. The quantity $\frac{Q}{T}$ is called entropy. It is a very important thermodynamic property of a system. It is also a state variable. $\frac{Q_H}{T_H}$ is the entropy received by the Carnot engine from hot reservoir and $\frac{Q_L}{T_L}$ is entropy given out by the Carnot engine to the cold reservoir. For reversible engines (Carnot Engine) both entropies should be same, so that the change

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